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Know What God Wants You to Do Every Day

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Know What God Wants You to Do Every Day

God reveals His will to us through: His Word, the Holy Spirit, other people, and providential circumstances.

There is an old story about a man trapped on the top of his house during a flood or hurricane or tsunami (insert your own natural disaster). The water is swiftly rising. As this man sits on his roof, fearful of being swept away by the current, he cries out to God, “God please help me.”

A few moments later, a friend arrives with his boat. “Hey, friend, need a ride to safety?” he asks.

“No,” replies the man on top of his house. “God is going to help me.”

An hour later, the water is up to the gutters. A voluntary rescue person comes by on his yellow raft. “Hey, let’s get you off of there and on to safety,” he yells.

But the man on top of his house refuses to go. “God is going to help me.”

Another hour passes and now the water is halfway up the roof. The man is now on top of his chimney, nervously looking down at certain death.

Fortunately, a Red Cross volunteer swings by in a canoe and offers to take him to safety. But the man refuses. “No, God is going to help me.”

A couple of hours pass by and the water sweeps over the top of the house. The man is carried away by the current and drowns. When he gets to Heaven, he says to God, “I thought you were going to help me.”

God and says to the man, “I sent a boat, an inflatable raft, and a canoe—but you refused each one.”

And you laughed, right? But quite often this is a perfect analogy of our attempts to know God’s plan for our lives. We act as if God’s will is some sort of vague, mysterious amazing thing. It’s as if we want God to show us what He wants us to do, but we don’t really think He will make it clear to us. Ask God what He wants you to do ... and then wait expectantly for Him to give you answer!

Q. How do you most often figure out what you should do?

Q. Do you usually consider what God might want for you to do? How do you determine this?

Many times, what God wants us to do is very clear. When we talk about knowing what God wants us to do this is sometimes referred to as “knowing God’s will.” We can know God’s will in two different ways: through His *general* will and His *specific* will.

God’s *general* will is always clear. We find His general will clearly revealed in Scripture. When we are considering whether or not God is directing us to do something, some decisions are objective enough to be eliminated on the basis of whether or not they conform to God’s Word. God will never lead us in a direction that will violate the principles He has given in the Bible. For example, He would not lead lie or cheat or steal, because this is clearly taught in the Bible as something that is wrong. Or He would not want you to pursue a relationship with a person who is married, because you would be committing adultery, which is in direct violation of what is taught throughout the Bible.

In Psalm 32:8 we read,

“I will instruct and teach you about how you should live. I will advise you as I look you in the eye.”

As we immerse ourselves in prayer and in the study of God’s Word, He will give us His wisdom to make decisions that are compatible with His principles.

Proverbs 3:5-6 reminds us, “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not rely on your own understanding.”

Here are some principles that can guide us as we seek to determine God’s general will:

God has a plan for your life. Jeremiah 29:11 says, “For I know what I have planned for you,” says the Lord. “I have plans to prosper you, not to harm you. I have plans to give you a future filled with hope.”

God desires that each and every person have a relationship with Him through His Son, Jesus Christ. 1 Timothy 2:4-5 tells us, “He [God] wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth. For there is one God and one intermediary between God and humanity, Christ Jesus, himself human.”

God promises to give us wisdom if we ask Him and believe that He will give it. James 1:5 tells us, “But if anyone is deficient in wisdom, he should ask God, who gives to all generously and without reprimand, and in these words, “I am able to do all things through the one who strengthens me.” And Isaiah 41:10 says, “Don’t be afraid, for I am with you! Don’t be frightened, for I am your God! I strengthen you—yes, I help you—yes, I uphold you with my saving right hand!”

Q. What new thought or idea has been presented to you so far in this lesson?

God’s *specific* will at times is difficult to see clearly. Does he want me to take a job in a different city ... or stay with the one that I have? Does he want me to marry this person that I am currently dating ... or should I wait for someone else? Should I buy a new car ... or a used one? Should I go to the university ... or stay home with my family?

You can be sure of one thing: No one has perfect insight into God’s specific will. The soundest, most mature believers can and do make mistakes about God’s specific will. However, in determining God’s specific will there are some absolutes that never change. God reveals His specific will through His Word, the Bible (Psalm 119:105), through the Holy Spirit (John 14:26), through other people (Proverbs 15:22), and through providential circumstances (Proverbs 16:9).

As you study God’s Word and talk with Him about the specific things in your life that you need direction and discernment for, here are some questions that can help you make a decision. Each one of these questions is based on principles that run throughout the Bible. A specific Bible verse or passage is given for each principle as a reference, but you can find many other verses related to each question!

- Does it comply with the directions given in God’s written Word? (Psalm 119:133)
- Does it demonstrate love for God? (John 14:15)
- Does it demonstrate love for others? (Romans 13:9-10)
- Does it promote personal holiness? (1 Thessalonians 4:7)
- Does it reflect the fruit of the Spirit? (Galatians 5:22)
- Does it require faith and trust in God? (Hebrews 11:6)
- Does it make sense when you use reasoning that is based on God’s truth? (Romans 12:2)
- Does it generate a supernatural inner peace and calmness that cannot be attributed to your circumstances? (Philippians 4:6-7)

Q. Is there any situation or relationship in your life right now for you to apply some of these questions to?

You do not have to be able to answer “yes” to each and every question in order to determine that the direction you are heading is the one God wants for you. There may be several questions that you simply cannot answer, but there should be a clear consensus among those that you can. If the answer is “no” to any of these questions, take time to wait on God to give you more confirmation before taking action. Many times, people believe God is leading them into an area, and He may be, but they plunge forward without getting His confirmation. Be patient and willing to wait on God.

Take time to recognize God’s direction through insights, impressions, conversations, circumstances, and counsel that may be God’s specific guidance. God promises to give us strength and courage for whatever life brings.

Application

Q. In what ways can you apply the principles contained in this lesson to your life right now?